

The Colophon of the Bhagavadgita

Discourse 1 — Condensed Study Text

Lossless condensation, with headings, of Swami Krishnananda's Commentary on the Bhagavadgita

1. Theory, Practice, Realisation: What the Colophon Says

The colophon closing every chapter of the Gita — brahmavidyāyām yogaśāstre śrīkṛṣṇārjunasaṁvāde — is no perfunctory formula; nothing in the Gita, not even the recurring śrībhagavānuvāca, is redundant. Where commentaries multiply the Gita's teaching into karma yoga, raja yoga, bhakti yoga, jnana yoga, a synthesis of yogas, an art of living, the Gita's own colophon names exactly three things: theory, practice, realisation. As theoretical physics conceptualises the fundamental structure of matter, and that insight then renders matter tractable for practical, technological use — an unknown object is fearsome; intimacy with it eases handling — so the Gita moves through Brahma-vidya (theory) to Yoga Shastra (practice) to the Krishna-Arjuna dialogue (realisation).

2. Brahma-vidya: The Science of the Absolute

Brahma-vidya is the science of the Absolute: a mode of thought able to comprehend, at any moment, the total structure of things — not merely an object's inner constituents but its relations to everything else. A thing's reality lies not only in itself but in whatever determines, restricts, influences, conditions, and defines it.

3. The Illusion of Isolated Individuality

This bears on the illusion of individuality. We seem self-contained — alone in our rooms, unrelated to what's outside. But we are not unconnected: physical, social, political, and psychological “atmospheres” condition us continuously, even in solitude. Total, unconditioned individuality is therefore a chimera.

4. The Relational Logic of Perception

The same relational logic governs perception. Consciousness of A as independent of B presupposes a relation between them. Perceiving an object as red is simultaneously a distinction from all that is not red; if redness were universal, it would be imperceptible. A thing's positive character is thus inseparable from what it is not — the “not-ness” is itself a factor acting on the object. Even our being human is conditioned by not being animal: nothing “outside” us is truly outside — everything exerts influence, in quality and in quantity. To think in an “Absolute” way is to recognise the whole structure of the

universe even within an atom, much as one can, in a sense, summon “the whole government” through a single official, though no official is the government; any object draws sustenance from the entire universe.

5. Partial Vision Versus Total Perception

Brahma-vidya, then, is self-education in perceiving the world — including one's own self — within this totality of relations, so that no partial vision passes for the Absolute. Ordinary perception is always partial, bound to some condition (marketplace, station, office, house); we rarely move past the outward appearance of these conditions to their relations with everything else. This is difficult because the mind is sensorily externalised, while total perception is neither purely external nor internal but a blend: we stand between our perceiving capacity and the perceived object. In total perception we transcend both self and object, becoming the blending consciousness that harmonises seer and seen — any two faces of reality.

MARGIN NOTE — beside “it is very difficult for us to see the relation between cause and effect”:

“Read in CD Sharma” + a cross-reference to the Buddhist middle path.

6. The Verses That Carry the Teaching's Import

Brahma-vidya is not the repetition of Upanishadic, Brahma-Sutra, or Gita phrases but consciousness entering the very import of the teaching, as suggested in verses such as 7.7, 10.20, 11.5, 11.8, 13.12, and 13.13 — the last describing the Total as having hands, feet, eyes, heads, and ears everywhere, enveloping all, because it is neither subject nor object. In the total perception of things we are neither ourselves nor other than ourselves — something beyond both what we are and what is other than what we are. This is the final import of the Brahma-vidya aspect of the Gita.

7. From Theory to Practice: Yoga Shastra

Theory must lead to practice. This Brahma-vidya — the knowledge of the integrality of things — must be applied daily: in teacups, fountain pens, angry gestures, prejudices, desires, attractions, repulsions. We must be whole persons at all times, not whole in the office and fractional at home; behaving differently in different settings fragments the personality and is not a holistic life. Yoga Shastra is this daily application of consciousness, mind, and attitude to everything in light of Brahma-vidya's lesson, and its purpose is *kṛṣṇārjunasaṁvāda* — the soul's conversation with God. Arjuna beholding the mighty Krishna symbolises the soul beholding the Cosmic Being in daily life.

8. Tuning to God's Wavelength

Who can converse with God? Only one who blazes in purity of spirit as God does — one who has transcended the limitations of flesh and bone and the socially/politically conditioned psyche. The “wavelength” of individuality and of God are so disparate that there is ordinarily no mingling; God’s broadcasting station transmits constantly, but our receiving sets are too feeble to catch the message. Yoga Shastra is the tuning of that receiving set to God’s wavelength; its purpose is direct daily contact with God — not merely thinking of, praying to, or feeling toward Him, nor postponing realisation to some future day. Since God vibrates in every atom as the sun vibrates in the solar system, He must be confronted now.

9. God as Here and Now

MARGIN NOTE — beside “God is a here and a now, and not an afterwards or a somewhere or a someone”:
“very Krishnamurtian.”

God is free of the limitations of space and time; contact with Him is contact with timelessness, eternity, just-ness, now-ness, here-ness — the final import of the Gita’s teaching, the soul’s realisation of perfection achieved through Yoga Shastra, grounded in the theoretical education of Brahma-vidya.

10. Know, Do, Realise: Entering God Daily

The sequence is: first know, then do, then realise — echoed in the Gita’s eleventh chapter, where mere seeing and knowing are insufficient; one must enter into God daily, not merely hold Him as an outer whitewash that never becomes part of one’s structure. Where is this God to be entered daily? Not in some unimaginable infinity: per 13.13 and 7.7 (“outside God, nothing exists”), no distance separates us from Him — contact is distanceless and timeless, provided we open ourselves to His illumination and melt the ego that insists “I too exist, alongside God.” This ego-affirmation is, in essence, the biblical fall of Satan (“If you are there, I am also there”) — and it persists even in the devotee’s stance of “God, Thou art, but I am also there to contemplate You.” The devotee must melt rather than remain a separate contemplator, so that God possesses him — as the ocean receives the rivers, as the world melts into a consciousness that is pure now and here.

11. Conclusion: The Threefold Gita

The Gita, in sum, is Brahma-vidya (theoretical understanding of the cosmos’ structure), Yoga Shastra (daily practised discipline), and śrīkrṣṇārjunasaṁvāda (the soul’s constant contact with God in practical life) — true divine life.